

Description & Eligibility

Contestants will demonstrate foundational and advanced knowledge of modern computer networking, including architectures, protocols, hardware, connectivity, and security. This event evaluates real-world concepts used in today's enterprise environments. Any secondary or postsecondary division contestant may enter this objective event.

Contestant Must Supply

- Published and/or unpublished non-electronic written reference materials
- (Optional) Cordless calculator: Electronic devices will be monitored according to ACT standards. See NLC Calculator Guidelines. Contestants who violate this rule will be disqualified.

Equipment/Supplies Provided

- Computer and software

Contest Notes

- Method of evaluation: objective
- AI Policy Level 1 *No AI Allowed*
- Previous Business Professionals of America tests and/or sample tests (handwritten, photocopied or keyed) may not be taken into the testing area. Violation of this rule will result in disqualification.
- At NLC, contestants will take IT Specialist Networking certification as part of the event. Contestants passing this certification will have 50 points added to their event score.
 - A Pearson profile must be created at <https://certiport.pearsonvue.com> before attending NLC
 - Contestants must include their BPA Contestant ID in their Pearson profile when they register
 - Certiport Parent/Legal Guardian Consent Form must be uploaded to: education@bpa.org
 - For more information on the exam, visit <https://certiport.pearsonvue.com>
 - Reference materials are not allowed for certification testing
- The top 10 contestants at Nationals will advance to a final round that includes a hands-on component. Scores from the preliminary round and the objective test will not carry over to the finals. Reference materials may be used during the application portion of the final round.
- Length of event
 - Preliminaries - No more than sixty (60) minutes for objective test
 - Preliminaries (Nationals only) - sixty (60) minutes for objective test, no more than fifty (50) minutes for certification test, and no more than sixty (60) minutes for performance component
 - Finals (Nationals only) - No more than sixty (60) minutes for performance component
- Entries vary by state

Contest Competencies

1. Design, configure, and troubleshoot computer networks using OSI/TCP-IP models, subnetting, and IPv4/IPv6 addressing to ensure scalable and secure connectivity
2. Install, configure, and troubleshoot computer hardware components to ensure reliable performance and minimize downtime in networked environments
3. Configure and manage core network services including DNS, DHCP, etc. to enable efficient name resolution, addressing, and resource discovery
4. Deploy and manage cloud, virtualization, and secure remote-access technologies to support scalable and hybrid network infrastructures
5. Administer directory services and operating systems to ensure secure authentication, centralized management, and efficient enterprise operations
6. Identify key features of Wi-Fi 6/6E/7, explain how they improve network efficiency and performance, and describe appropriate use cases for modern wireless deployments

7. Compare cloud networking models and explain how networking, security, and access controls differ between public, private, hybrid, and multi-cloud environments
8. Explain how SD-WAN functions, identify its advantages over traditional WANs, and describe how SD-WAN improves application performance and network reliability
9. Define zero-trust networking, explain its core principles, and describe how it is implemented to secure modern enterprise networks